

KALAHARI DESERT

A thirsty land where life finds a way

Covering an area of about 350,000 sq miles (900,000 sq km) in southern Africa, the Kalahari comprises a mixture of dry savanna and extensive areas of sand dunes. In summer, daytime temperatures can exceed 104°F (40°C), but the heat is moderated by altitude, with most of the region lying above 2,630 ft (800 m). The name Kalahari comes from the local Tswana language: *Kgalagadi* means waterless place. However, although it is commonly called a desert on account of its aridity, the Kalahari supports a far greater range of plant and animal life than a true desert.

Temporary greening

The Kalahari has a summer rainy season, when 4–20 in (100–500 mm) of rain may fall and parts of the region may become relatively green. However, the rains may fail completely in some years and as a result, the plants and animals have numerous adaptations to periodic drought.

For example, the plants of the dry savanna conserve water by producing tough, succulent or needlelike leaves and they take advantage of the rains to store water in roots, tubers, stems, and large, watery fruits such as melons and cucumbers.

The area has a diverse range of animals, including large herbivores such as antelopes and elephants, as well as predators such as lions, cheetahs, leopards, hyenas, wild dogs, and birds of prey. Other notable animals include aardvarks, ostriches, and meerkats. In recent years, the movement of larger herbivores has been restricted by cattle fencing, and wild predators have been persecuted by livestock farmers.



GEMSBOK

KEEPING A COOL HEAD
Among a variety of adaptations to the heat, the gemsbok pants through its nose to cool blood in the fine capillaries in the nostrils. Blood entering the brain is cooled by a close-knit network of vessels below it.

More than 400 species of plants

SURVIVAL FOOD
The deep roots of the camel thorn acacia help it to survive droughts, when its flowers and large seed pods become vital survival food for many of the Kalahari's herbivores. The leaves are protected by thorns, which deter browsers.



CAMEL THORN ACACIA

SAFE REFUGE

Colonies of 100 or more pairs of sociable weavers breed in a huge, multichambered nest, usually woven around the branches of a tree. Parent birds are aided by unrelated adults and older offspring, allowing them to raise up to four broods in succession.

SOCIABLE WEAVER

Contains the world's largest unbroken expanse of sand

